FITNESS BASICS

How much activity adults need, how to tell how hard you're working, and an 8-week walking plan that starts from zero.

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GUIDE / VERIFY: General wellness information, not medical advice. It does not replace care from a doctor, nurse, pharmacist or other qualified professional. **Talk to your health-care provider before starting a new exercise, diet or health plan, especially if you have a medical condition.**

1. HOW MUCH IS ENOUGH

WHO	FEDERAL GUIDELINE (PER WEEK UNLESS NOTED)
Adults	**150 to 300 minutes** of moderate activity (brisk walking), **or 75 to 150 minutes** of vigorous activity (jogging), or a mix. Plus **muscle-strengthening on 2 or more days**. *(WL-02)*
Older adults	The same, as able, plus **balance training**. If a condition limits you, be as active as you safely can.
Children 6 to 17	**60 minutes or more every day**, mostly moderate to vigorous, with muscle- and bone-strengthening (climbing, jumping) at least 3 days a week.
Everyone	**Move more, sit less.** Any amount helps, even a few minutes at a time, and some is better than none.

2. HOW HARD AM I WORKING? THE TALK TEST

EFFORT	YOU CAN...	EXAMPLES
Light	Sing.	Strolling, light housework.
Moderate	Talk, but not sing.	Brisk walking, easy cycling, raking leaves, water aerobics.
Vigorous	Say only a few words before pausing for breath.	Jogging, hiking uphill, fast cycling, shoveling heavy snow, singles tennis.

One minute of vigorous activity counts about the same as two minutes of moderate.

3. 8-WEEK WALKING PLAN

For someone starting from little or no exercise. Walk at a moderate pace (the talk test). Start each walk with 3 to 5 minutes of easy walking, and end the same way. If a week feels hard, repeat it before moving on.

WEEK	EACH WALK	WALKS A WEEK	WEEKLY TOTAL	DONE (CHECK EACH WALK)
1	10 minutes	5	50 min	□ □ □ □ □
2	12 minutes	5	60 min	□ □ □ □ □
3	15 minutes	5	75 min	□ □ □ □ □
4	18 minutes	5	90 min	□ □ □ □ □
5	20 minutes	5	100 min	□ □ □ □ □
6	23 minutes	5	115 min	□ □ □ □ □

7	26 minutes	5	130 min	□ □ □ □ □
8	30 minutes	5	**150 min**	□ □ □ □ □

After week 8 you're meeting the adult guideline. From there: walk a little faster, add hills, or add a few minutes, but change only one thing at a time.

4. MAKING IT STICK

- Put it on the calendar like an appointment: same time, same place.
- Walk with someone. You're less likely to skip.
- Break it up: three 10-minute walks count the same as one 30-minute walk.
- Have a bad-weather plan: indoor walking at a mall or store, stairs, an exercise video.
- Good shoes matter more than anything else you can buy for walking.
- Drink water before and after, more in heat. *(WL-05)*
- Wear something bright or reflective if you walk near traffic or after dark.
- Track it (below, or a step counter). Seeing progress keeps people going.

STOP AND GET MEDICAL HELP if you have chest pain or pressure, severe shortness of breath, dizziness or fainting, or pain that doesn't go away. Talk with your health-care provider before starting if you have heart disease, diabetes, high blood pressure, joint problems, are pregnant, or haven't been active in a long time.

5. ACTIVITY LOG

WEEK OF	MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	SUN

SOURCES / FURTHER REFERENCE

1. U.S. Department of Health and Human Services: Physical Activity Guidelines for Americans, 2nd edition; Move Your Way. health.gov/moveyourway
2. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention: Physical Activity Basics; Measuring Physical Activity Intensity. cdc.gov/physical-activity-basics
3. American Heart Association: Recommendations for Physical Activity in Adults and Kids. heart.org

IMPORTANT: General guidance for healthy people. Your health-care provider can tell you what's right for you. This document reflects the sources above as of November 2026.